

The Softer Side

He can be shy, has a sweet tooth and is quite fit

Reticence and shyness are qualities that are generally not associated with politicians. Lal Krishna Advani's first meeting with Ratan Tata, known to be equally shy, ended within minutes. Both of them shook hands, exchanged greetings and waited for the other to start the conversation. When neither took the initiative, they shook hands again and that was the end of the meeting. Both Advani and Tata recall that first non-meeting and still laugh about it.

And quite atypical of politicians, Advani is also easily moved to tears. He is not one to believe that to be seen crying in public is a sign of weakness. Advani wept like a child at a special screening of the Aamir Khan-starrer *Taare*

Zameen Par, a poignant story of a dyslexic child. Even as an occasional writer, Advani has probably penned more words than most politicians have ever read, but he is a voracious reader too, of all genres from sci-fi, literature, fiction and non-fiction, avoiding only horror and fantasy.

During his campaign travels, he has been using his e-book reader, gifted by Narendra Modi. In addition, he keeps his iPod and palm-top with him. After a grueling day Advani likes to unwind with music, generally ghazals by Ghulam Ali and Jagjit Singh. His daughter Pratibha, who he is closest to, is constantly in touch.

Unlike many politi-



ADVANI WITH FAMILY
 (ABOVE); WRINGING HANDS
 IS ONE OF HIS QUIRKS



cians, Advani does not drink too much tea or coffee on the campaign

trail. His preferred beverage remains milk or lassi, which perhaps explains why at 81, his fitness levels would be the envy of many half his age. Up by 6.45 am, he starts his day with a 20-minute walk in the lawns of his house.

A frugal eater, he considers eating as the most "insignificant act", eating three small meals a day. A vegetarian since the age of 11, he prefers home-cooked food, comprising one chapati, vegetable, dal and curd. But he does indulge his sweet tooth with liberal helpings of rice kheer, preferably cooked by his wife Kamla, and chocolates.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

RAVI'S SAMPI



**A LARGER-THAN-LIFE ADVANI
 DEFINES THE BJP CAMPAIGN**

is the last of a vanishing breed: "in a polity dominated by shamelessness, his commitment to honesty and probity is impeccable." For some, he is the Hindu nationalist who mined mythology to divide the mind of India. There are no portraits of this man in pastels. At last he has offered himself to the Judgement Day, a singular act that may end up in redemption or repudiation. This time, no one can ask him to share the glory—or the pain. It will be his own. It will be all about biography, for ideology is still flexible. As he returns to the base from the battlefield one evening, he asks the air stewardess to play the ghazals of Jagjit Singh. The journey began more than 60 years ago in Karachi, when the student of the city's St. Patrick's High School for Boys walked from a tennis court to the nearest RSS shakha. He has never stopped walking since then. Even now, it's a lone endeavour, but the patience is running out. This time he has to win more than an argument. He has to win a country he thinks has never comprehended him.

with Bhavna Vij-Aurora

In the kind of personality-driven campaign that Advani leads, it is not the partners who matter the most. He has given himself to the people: judge me, take me, or reject me. They have never had an opportunity to be the arbiters of his destiny, though all of them have an opinion on him. For an ardent admirer and adviser like S. Gurumurthy, he